



With Core i5 release pending EVGA, an NVIDIA only vendor surprises by announcing their P55 platform

Intel Clarkdale

Intel's 32-nm plans become a little clearer as it announces three sets of parts: Core i9, Core i5 and Core i3

CPU test

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A couple of years ago, choosing a CPU was a simple as buying a loaf of bread. Those that wanted performance bought a Core 2 Duo, while the value segment bought an Athlon 64. The only decision that needed to be made was the extent of expenditure. In fact, up to a year ago, there was very little competition between Intel and AMD, and before you scoff at our dementia for conjuring such a statement hear us out. Intel ruled the high-end and upper-mid-range of the market. If anyone wanted to spend upward of Rs. 8,000 on a processor they would almost certainly

(fanboys aside) buy an Intel. Those with a lower budget would get an AMD. Intel has been on an undoubted roll since the Core architecture and its fabrication plants have been shipping out newer, faster revisions quicker than we can buy them. AMD's Phenom CPUs bombed badly, and the strong-on-paper architecture scored no benchmark love.

Fast-forward to around nine months back and the introduction of the Phenom II. We've seen AMD's CPUs get faster; in fact their quickest CPUs are as quick as the fastest Core 2 Quads around – a fact easily verified by our tests. So the mid-range segment has become competitive again. And you, our readers and adopters of such technology, have finally

got the painful pleasure of a choice.

Our CPU test coincides with an important launch. Intel's Core i5 CPUs – the mid-range derivative of the Core i7 (Nehalem) architecture are soon to be out. Unfortunately, Intel slated this launch for the first week of September meaning these CPUs would be under embargo till after this issue of Digit hits stands. Despite some motherboard vendors such as ASUS, Gigabyte and MSI happily shipping us Intel P55 chipset-based motherboards, we couldn't test these CPUs thanks to these awkward dates. Till October then... meanwhile we have a very wide range of processors on show – from single cores to hyper-threading quad cores. From a humble

Rs. 2,160 to a stupendous Rs. 56,000, our test candidates strut their stuff.

Processors up to Rs. 5,000 - Basic(ally) Sensible

Let's face it – you pay for what you get. Another fact – Rs. 5,000 will buy you a lot of processing power, much more than you could have bought a year ago. Our CPU test comes at a time when both Intel and AMD have recently announced price cuts – in fact, the price cuts were announced just as we finished testing. As things stand today processor prices are pretty much rock bottom, at least in this category. When spending not more than Rs. 5,000 you should expect something that can get you through all everyday

New Horizons

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